girl.

By Megan Mostyn-Brown

MONDAY

HANNAH: My sister Lizzie died today. Wow, what a weird thing to say, you know? Because it's true. I mean, it sounds like the beginning of a poem that your teacher would read in English class or somethin' – "My sister Lizzie died today . . . dadum . . . dadum . . . dadum." Yeah. It's not like we didn't expect it . . . she's been missing for like, months. And even before that she was always in and out. Runnin' away n' shit. So mom and I were always like, "Lizzie's gone". . . Not like we said it to each other on a daily basis or even said it at all. But it was always just there hangin' in the air: Lizzie's gone, dot, dot, dot.

INTRODUCTION

Hannah's week starts with a sentence she can't quite wrap her head around: Lizzie's gone. And while everyone expects her to cry – to break down -- she's stuck thinking about morgue tiles and why Lizzie's life has been reduced to a newspaper statistic. Hannah's story reveals the kind of family people don't put in sympathy cards: the fights, the missed moments, the quiet way a daughter can disappear while parents chase the memory of one who's already gone. There are so many things you can't tell just by looking at her.

From girl. by Megan Mostyn-Brown

HANNAH: Lizzie's gone, dot, dot, dot. Maybe that's what's different, no ellipses. It's, ahhh, what do ya call it? Yeah, a declarative sentence, I think. Anyway, not it's the kind of sentence with a period at the end of it. "Lizzie's gone" period. It's funny, you know? I didn't cry at all today. And I felt really bad because, well, you're supposed to cry when people die. But, honest to god, all I could think about all day is that if I were going to jump off a bridge, like her, I wouldn't do it in the middle of July. And that's f***ed up right? To be thinking about that instead of being sad. I would do it in November, or the beginning of March, on one of those days when you wake up with a chill because it never really stops drizzling. And the bridge would be just a little bit slippery. And the water really cold. And people would have to wonder, "Did she do it on purpose or was the hand rail too slick?"

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But today was the kind of day where it's like ninety-eight degrees before noon - not a cloud in the sky, and all anyone can manage to do is keep from sticking to the furniture. *(Pause)*

My mom hasn't said anything all day. I take that back. She hasn't said anything to me. She said thank you to the police officer who came to the house. And she mumbled Lizzie's name to the receptionist at the morgue. I didn't go in. I sat in a plastic chair in the hallway and counted the number of tiles on the floor from my feet to the front desk. There are seventy-two. They didn't have any pamphlets to read, which was really surprising because like every place in the hospital has at least one pamphlet. But, what would the morgue have pamphlets about?

Anyway, I'm glad I didn't go in with mom, you know, to look at the body and stuff. Because when people drown they get all blue and bloated; not like I've ever seen it, but that's what happens in movies. I'd like to think of Lizzie like that picture, the one of Ophelia, I don't remember who painted it, but it's Ophelia floating on her back in this pond and she's wearing a really beautiful dress with a crown of flowers on her head. That's how I'd like to think of her. *(Pause)*

There's going to be a funeral. And who are we gonna invite? Because mom and I don't know who Lizzie's friends are. She stopped telling us stuff like that years ago. Mom pressed her for it. And they would fight. You know, screaming, yelling, breaking things etc . . . Pretty soon she just stopped coming home at all. Now that she's gone for good, it's like we can erase all the bad shit - Wow. It sounds like I'm glad she's dead. *(Beat)*

Um, I guess it'll just be me and mom at the funeral. Jesus . . . maybe her friends, wherever or whomever they are, are having a little funeral for her somewhere else and one of them's gonna get up to say a few words about her. I'd like to think that's true. I mean, someone somewhere HAS to have a few words to say about her . . .

TUESDAY

I've been thinking, like a lot. It sucks cuz all I can think about is Lizzie. There was this article in the paper today about "Lost Youth" and they mentioned her, saying how sad it was that

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her life ended so soon and what a statement it made on "the demise of adolescence in our society". Then they gave all these statistics about suicide and that's it. They didn't even talk to us. Or list any details about her life. They just mentioned her name, some facts about her death, and then placed her in a section of a pie chart. Jesus, they left out everything. It's like they felt sorry for her without even knowing what really -- I mean she was a f***ing drug addict. *(Beat)*

Um . . . this one night right before she ran away for good, this car pulls up in front of the house and whoever's in the driver's seat sorta just throws Lizzie onto the lawn. And she's layin' with her face in the grass and I don't know if she's . . . . So, I go outside to see what's goin' on, the car's driven away by then, and all the shit from her purse is all over the lawn, and when I roll her over she's laughing, and her eyes, well, I can only see the white parts. And she says my name in this really gross way. And I'm so afraid mom's gonna wake up or that the neighbors will see. So I try to get her to be quiet so I can get her into the house and like splash water on her face or somethin', because you know that's supposed to sober people up, I guess.

And I pinch my arm really hard so I won't . . . See, cuz all of this . . . . It's just a lot when you're fifteen. See I've started – well . . . *(Beat)* For a while now I've been *(Beat)* hurting myself. *(Pause)*

WEDNESDAY

Um . . so, so last night, the house is like suffocating quiet. So I use a *(Beat)* straight razor. I usually don't. I prefer the pink Bic kind . . . does the job, less damage. So I use a straight razor and after it's like fireworks and deep breaths and the good kind of weak knees all at once. Um . . . until I notice, well . . . *(As the next passage goes on Hannah gets really into it, like she's there)* there's no point in being graphic. Suffice to say there's a lot of blood and it won't stop no matter how much pressure I put on it and I start to get worried cuz I feel sort of faint and I don't know what to do to make it stop. And I don't want to call my mom, so I walk to the emergency room, which is good, because they stitch me up. Ten stitches

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with the kind of thread that will dissolve when the wound is all healed. But since I'm a minor, and they know that my arm isn't the accident I play it off to be, they call Mom and make me sit in this office with a nurse who asks me if I've ever done anything like this before. Which is the stupidest question, because she can see the marks all over my arm. And I answer yes in this voice that doesn't sound like me at all and I can't look her in the eye, so I stare at the floor which has the exact same tiling as the morgue. She asks me how many years this has been going on and I say two. I lift up the salmon pink hospital gown and Jesus . . . . *(makes a vague gesture at her legs)* there's a lot. Like words carved . . . "Hate" "Ugly."

So I'm like . . . can I go home now? I'm a good person. I get straight A's, swear to God. I promise I won't do it again. I just wanna go home like really badly. But I can't leave until my mom gets here. And I think I'm gonna throw up or break into a million little pieces . . . so I stare at my toes cuz maybe, just maybe, if I make myself small enough, all of this will go away.

THURSDAY

I get up this morning and Mom's not a work. She's at home making plans for the funeral. All the knives were gone and my razor, you know, to shave my legs with, was missing. At dinner this evening we sat in complete silence. I don't know why we even go through the motions. And she served soup and a salad, you know, things you don't have to cut. And she acts like I didn't notice her peeking at my arms, I mean, it's not as though she's going to see anything anyway. I mean I haven't stopped. I can't. It's the only thing in this whole mess that's mine. So I've just moved my activities to a new region. Under here *(Gestures at her breasts but keeps looking straight out)* And the only thing that keeps me sane is this stupid fantasy where I clear everything off the table with one swoop of my arm, you know, like people do in movies when someone's like ROYALLY dicked them over and they want to make a point. Anyway, all the dishes go crashing to the floor and [Mom] just like sits there because she's so in shock that I did this horrible violent thing. Anyway, I take off all my

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clothes, strip down to my underwear so she can see all the marks and scars and I tell her where each one is from.

I'd say . . . *(the following passage should start out slow and then pick up with dizzying momentum)* This one right here, this I did the night you yelled at me when Lizzie broke curfew for like the eighty-seventh time. And this one is from when you missed my school play because you were too tired from roaming the city all night looking for her. And this . . . THIS . . . I did after I cleaned the house, scrubbed the floors, and EVERYTHING and you didn't even notice because SHE had stolen the stereo. This one I did after we picked her up from jail. These along my arm are the last six months she was missing. This one is from when you left me standing in front of the cashier with a conveyer belt full of groceries and a line of angry customers because you thought you saw her in the parking lot. And while all of the NORMAL families loaded brown bags into their station wagons to have REAL FAMILY DINNRS, I was the MOTHER and held your head in my lap while you cried because it wasn't her. This long one that curves from my wrist is because you haven't spoken to me since Monday when she died. I am HERE. I STILL EXIST! *(Long pause. She should be out of breath, dizzy. She takes a beat, composes herself and then. . . nothing)*

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AWARD HISTORY

2009 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
2020 National Qualifier
2020 National Qualifier – MS
2021 National Qualifier
2022 National Qualifier
2022 National Qualifier - MS
2023 National Qualifier
2024 National Qualifier
2024 National Qualifier - MS
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